ENGINEERING ANTI-PATTERN

The Campaign Cascade

Why cross-cutting initiatives multiply instead of completing — and the three ways out.

THE LOOP

⚡ Campaign	⏸ Stall	📢 Escalate	📡 Broadcast	📋 Track
Ship PRs across other teams' repos	Merging others' work is nobody's priority	Manager → Director → SVP chain	Signal decays at every level	New campaign to chase compliance

↻ Each incomplete campaign spawns the next

The Anti-Pattern: Human in the Loop, No Context in Hand

When a PR lands from the outside, the team doesn't know why it matters, what breaks if they ignore it, or how it fits their work. Someone else wrote the code — they lack the **skillset** to review or own it. It's an interruption that requires effort but provides no understanding. So it sits.

THREE WAYS OUT

PATH A

Automate Completely

Codemod, CI verification, canary rollout, auto-merge on green. Zero human touchpoints. If it can't be safely automated, it's not ready for a campaign.

Tradeoff: Only works for mechanically safe changes.

PATH B

Own It Vertically

A dedicated team permanently owns the cross-cutting concern with merge authority. It's their core job, not a side quest. They have context because they built the expertise.

Tradeoff: Requires permanent headcount and org commitment.

PATH C

Enable Horizontally

Declare the intent on each entity — what to do, why, migration guide, known gotchas — and give teams the skillset to act on it themselves.

Tradeoff: Hard to scale. Works best with strong team autonomy.

☠ THE DEAD ZONE

You create the PR but require them to merge. **No automation. No vertical ownership. No enablement.**
Just a human in the loop with no context. This is where campaigns die.

Automate completely, own it vertically, or enable horizontally.
The only wrong move is putting a human in the loop and leaving them in the dark.

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